Three First Moves for a Family Getting Ready Early

Sort it, share it, and pick a day to look again.

Mom is well. The family has started talking about getting ready, and the talk keeps pulling two ways: one of you wants to start touring places, and one of you would rather not discuss it.

Nothing has to happen this month. If you'd like something useful to do in between, start here. Three moves, in this order.

1

Sort what's been suggested: getting ready, or deciding?

Write down everything anyone in the family has suggested, including the ideas you disagree with. Beside each one, mark whether it's preparation, which helps whatever happens, or a decision, which would commit Mom to something. Putting her care notes in one folder is preparation. Choosing a building is a decision. Then ask Mom what she'd add, and what she wants. [1]

WHY Until the two are sorted apart, the relative who wants to tour and the one who'd rather not talk are answering different questions.

2

Agree who keeps the planning file

The planning file is wherever the family's lists and notes live: a folder, a notebook, a shared document. Ask who is willing to keep it up to date, and say plainly that keeping the file isn't the same as doing all the preparation. AARP's planning guide describes a similar role, a point person: someone to keep the process moving and make sure people understand what's been decided. [1]

WHY Preparation that looks like one big job lands on one person. A named keeper, and a list anyone can take a piece from, keeps the work where everyone can see it.

3

Pick a day to look again

Write a date on the page for the family's next look at it. The CDC's advice for a care plan is to update it every year, or more often if the person's health or medicines change. The Family Caregiver Alliance adds changes in the caregiving situation or in family members' own lives. Under the date, note a few everyday changes of that kind that would be a reason to talk sooner. [2] [3]

WHY A page with nothing to bring anyone back to it tends to stay in the drawer.

What to leave for later

- Where Mom would live if she ever needed more help. That's a decision, and it isn't due.
- Choosing between places, or putting them in order.
- A date for any move.
- Who does what in the long run. For now it's enough to know who has offered what.
- What any change in Mom would mean. That's for the professionals who assess her.

If something changes before that day

This page assumes Mom is well. If something about her health concerns you, tell her doctor. It doesn't need to wait for the date on the page.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't decide anything about Mom's care, choose where she lives or hand anyone a job. It puts three first moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've sorted preparation from decisions, agreed who keeps the file and written down a day to look again. The care interview adds the picture of today that a later look gets compared against: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Keeping Mom at the center of the plan and naming a point person follow AARP's Prepare to Care guide. Looking at a plan again each year, or when health, medicines or the family's circumstances change, follows the CDC and the Family Caregiver Alliance. The order, and the sorting of preparation from decisions, are ours.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting

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